a small preview of this tool. Along the lines of the examples we have presented, try to open other files as well. Remember, all of them won't work, but you may just end up knowing a little more about your system than you do now!

3.2 System Maintenance

Your computer, like any other machine or system, needs some maintenance, mostly preventive! You want to ensure that your system runs smoothly to keep Mr Murphy at bay—most system administrators feel that computers crash when it is most important that they run properly. In Windows, you would have used the disk defragmenter and scandisk tools; let's see what Linux offers in terms of system maintenance. As you've probably guessed, there are a lot of powerful options here as well.

With respect to operating systems, one of the most important maintenance tasks is updating it using patches released by the developer. No OS is completely secure. Hence the creators of OSes release patches in order to plug security holes, as and when they find any. Besides, the patches released may also contain certain bug fixes. Hence it is wise to keep your system up-to-date. If you are connected to the Net (we will describe configuring your computer to use the Internet later in this book), updating is easy. From within the user interface, go to the System (most flavours have this menu) and look for an option that says Update. If this doesn't work, look for a Maintenance menu and under it, look for an update option. While this takes care of inherent OS issues, there are a lot of other tasks you are advised to carry out to keep potential problems at bay.

Firstly, ensure that there is enough free space on all your partitions. If any of the partitions "overflow" (run out of space), the system is likely to show problems, even if there is lot more space available on other partitions. The command "df" shows